dislike Germans because of what the Nazis did to our countries during World War II but also because they used to be our feudal lords.

This loss is particularly striking in the case of Czechs and Slovenians, who were most closely connected with Germany and/or Austria. (The latter, through both its name and its geographical position, could actually be claimed as an Eastern European country: Ősterreich means 'Eastern Kingdom' and, if you are travelling from Prague or Ljubljana, you have to head *east* if you want to get to Vienna.) Among the oldest Viennese families, there are those whose family names still sound Slavic even though they are written in a German form. And it would be difficult for Slovenians to find a nation that was closer to them, in its political history or even ethnogenesis, than Austria. (Because of centuries in which they had a common border with Hungarian-ruled Croats, Slovenians have had less political and even cultural interaction with their immediate Slavic neighbours who are otherwise closest to them in language.) Or as an American writer put it: 'The bulk of Slovenians… had become "Austrian" (though not German) in the twelfth and fourteenth centuries. Culturally, but not linguistically, they are Austrians and with a certain amount of exaggeration one might say that the central and east Austrians are the only Germanised Slovenes, and the Slovenes the only non-Germanised Austrians – a definition that both sides would find most displeasing.'[37] Not necessarily so. Long before the above words were written, Ivan Cankar, the greatest Slovenian writer and most outspoken socialist politician of his time, who vigorously advocated the political union of Slovenians and other neighbouring Slavs, said in a public speech in 1913: 'In the cultural, let alone the linguistic sense there does not exist a Yugoslav question! Perhaps it did exist once, but it was resolved when the south Slav tribe split into four nations with four fully independent cultural lives. We are brothers in blood, cousins at least as far as the language is concerned; but in culture, as a result of several centuries of separate education, we are more alien to each other than is our Gorenjska Region farmer distant to a Tyrolian one or a winemaker from Gorica to one from Friuli.'

This 'nostalgia' for Central Europe got a real shape in the 1990s, when Poland, the Czech Republic, Slovakia and Hungary, the countries known as the Višegrad Four (after the town of Višegrad in Hungary where, in 1335, the kings of Bohemia, Hungary and Poland met), reclaimed the title of